OK 原本是个玩笑

The Joke That Became OK



一个拼写笑话，怎样变成了OK?

READ 纯净阅读

CHECK 中文核对

LEARN 词汇记忆

RECALL 回想巩固

英文原文

OK, often said to be the planet's most frequently spoken word, began as a newspaper gag. From 1838 abbreviations were all the vogue in Boston's papers, and the craze turned comic through deliberate misspellings: O.W. for 'oll wright', K.Y. for 'know yuse'. The humour lay in the persona of an uneducated bumpkin.

On 23 March 1839 a Boston Morning Post satire took a swipe at a contemporary, the Providence Journal, over a mock society parodying an ordinance against ringing dinner bells. It carried the first known 'o.k.', glossed as 'all correct'. The letters stood for a knowingly illiterate 'oll korrect'. The presumed writer was the editor, Charles Gordon Greene.

Partisan politics propagated the letters nationwide. In 1840 Martin Van Buren, the incumbent president, sought re-election. His New York backers, punning on his nickname 'Old Kinderhook', after his birthplace, formed the Democratic O.K. Club, making the letters a double-meaning slogan. That November William Henry Harrison unseated him, 234 electoral votes to 60.

On 30 March 1840 the New York Morning Herald printed a fabricated smear: the former president Andrew Jackson, a supposedly inept speller, had marked paperwork O.K., for 'Ole Kurrek'. Jackson spelled reasonably well and never marked documents O.K. Within about twenty years, people did so in earnest. The bogus notation was merely premature.

Rival stories offered exotic pedigrees: Choctaw 'okeh' and Greek 'ola kala'. Authoritative dictionaries favoured Choctaw as late as 1961. In 1963–64 the linguist Allen Walker Read excavated the neglected Boston provenance from archival newspapers in six influential American Speech articles. Most dictionaries now embrace his derivation, a pedigree of bad spelling and dinner-bell satire.

中文译文

OK常被称为世界上最常说的词，起初却只是报纸上的一个笑话。从1838年起，波士顿报纸流行起缩写，又故意把词拼错来逗乐，例如用O.W.代表“oll wright”，用K.Y.代表“know yuse”。笑点在于装出一个没受过教育的乡下人的口吻。

1839年3月23日，《波士顿晨邮报》刊出一篇讽刺文，借一个戏仿禁敲开饭铃法令的虚构社团，挖苦同期的《普罗维登斯日报》。文中出现了已知最早的“o.k.”，并解释为“all correct”，即完全正确。这两个字母实际取自故意写错的“oll korrect”。文章的推定作者是编辑查尔斯·戈登·格林。

党派政治把这两个字母传播到了全国。1840年，在任总统马丁·范布伦谋求连任。他在纽约的支持者拿他根据出生地得来的绰号“Old Kinderhook”玩双关，成立民主党O.K.俱乐部，让OK成了一句兼具两重意思的竞选口号。当年11月，威廉·亨利·哈里森以234张选举人票对60张击败了他。

1840年3月30日，《纽约先驱晨报》刊出一则捏造的抹黑故事，说前总统安德鲁·杰克逊不擅拼写，曾在公文上批注O.K.，代表“Ole Kurrek”。实际上，杰克逊的拼写并不差，也从未这样批过文件。不过，在大约二十年内，人们果真开始认真使用这种批注。那种虚构的批注用法，不过是比实际流行早了一些。

其他词源说法另寻异域来历，例如乔克托语的“okeh”和希腊语的“ola kala”。直到1961年，权威词典仍倾向于乔克托语说。1963至1964年，语言学家艾伦·沃克·里德从报纸档案中发掘出被忽略的波士顿起源，并在《美国语言》发表了六篇影响深远的文章。如今，大多数词典都接受他的词源解释：这个词的身世，原来连着故意错拼和开饭铃讽刺文。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

abbreviation n.
缩写
From 1838 abbreviations were all the

all the vogue idiom
极为流行的
1838 abbreviations were all the vogue

deliberate adj.
故意的
comic through deliberate misspellings:

misspelling n.
拼写错误
comic through deliberate misspellings:

lie in phr.v.
在于
The humour lay in the persona of an

persona n.
扮演的角色；人物形象
The humour lay in the persona of an

satire n.
讽刺文章；讽刺作品
1839 a Boston Morning Post satire

take a swipe at idiom
挖苦；抨击
took a swipe at a contemporary, the

ordinance n.
法令；条例
an ordinance against ringing dinner

gloss as v.phr.
被解释为
first known 'o.k.', glossed as 'all

partisan adj.
党派的
Partisan politics propagated the

propagate v.
传播；推广
Partisan politics propagated the

incumbent adj.
在任的
Buren, the incumbent president, sought

pun on phr.v.
拿……玩双关
His New York backers, punning on his

slogan n.
口号
the letters a double-meaning slogan.

fabricated adj.
捏造的
Herald printed a fabricated smear:

inept adj.
不擅长的；笨拙的
a supposedly inept speller, had marked

bogus adj.
虚假的
The bogus notation was merely

premature adj.
过早的
bogus notation was merely premature.

authoritative adj.
权威的
Authoritative dictionaries favoured

provenance n.
起源；出处
the neglected Boston provenance from

derivation n.
词源；由来
now embrace his derivation, a pedigree

文中词汇与搭配

补充词汇共33项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

frequently adv.phr.
最频繁地；最常

gag n.
笑话；逗乐的噱头

craze n.
风潮；一时的狂热

comic adj.
滑稽的；逗乐的

humour n.
幽默；笑点

uneducated adj.
未受教育的

bumpkin n.
乡下土包子

contemporary n.
同期的报刊；同代者

mock adj.
虚构来戏仿的

parody v.
戏仿；滑稽模仿

knowingly adv.
明知地；有意地

illiterate adj.
不识字的；像文盲一样的

presumed adj.
推定的

editor n.
编辑

re-election n.
再次当选；连任

backer n.
支持者

birthplace n.
出生地

double-meaning adj.
有双重含义的

unseat v.
使落选；使失去职位

electoral vote n.phr.
选举人票

smear n.
抹黑；诽谤故事

supposedly adv.
据说；据称

paperwork n.
公文；文书

reasonably adv.
相当地；还算

in earnest idiom
认真地；当真地

notation n.
批注；记号

exotic adj.
异域的

pedigree n.
身世；来历

excavate v.
发掘；查出

neglected adj.
被忽略的

archival adj.
档案中的

influential adj.
有重要影响的

embrace v.
接受；采纳

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 From 1838 _____ were all the vogue in Boston's papers,

02 Partisan politics _____ the letters nationwide.

03 The bogus notation was merely _____.

04 Most dictionaries now embrace his _____,

文章主线

- 玩笑 1838年起，波士顿报纸流行故意拼错词再缩写；1839年出现已知最早的“o.k.”。
- 原义 o.k.取自all correct的故意错拼oll korrect，意为“完全正确”，笑点在模仿文盲口吻。
- 助推 1840年，范布伦阵营以绰号Old Kinderhook的缩写OK，兼指他本人和“完全正确”，用作竞选口号。
- 流传 范布伦败选，OK仍流传；杰克逊用它批文件的传闻是捏造，但约二十年内人们已认真如此批注。
- 考证 语言学家里德于1963至1964年查旧报，重建波士顿词源；多数词典采纳，取代早先乔克托语等说法。

参考答案　1 abbreviations 2 propagated 3 premature 4 derivation